

Alex F. Osborn

The Inventor of Brainstorming & Applied Imagination

1888–1966 · Advertising executive (BBDO) · co-founder, Creative Education Foundation

[portrait]

Alex F. Osborn

"It is easier to tone down a wild idea than to think up a new one."

"Quantity breeds quality."

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

Before Osborn, 'having ideas' in a meeting was unstructured and judgemental. He gave the world the first explicit method for generating ideas as a group — brainstorming — and the rule that still underpins ideation: defer judgement. Almost every tool in Units 7 traces back to him.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

American advertising executive, the 'O' in the agency BBDO. Frustrated by how criticism killed ideas in meetings, he developed and named brainstorming, and founded the Creative Education Foundation and the Creative Problem Solving (CPS) process with Sidney Parnes.

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
Brainstorming	Group ideation under four rules of deferred judgement
The four rules	Defer judgement · quantity · build on ideas · welcome wild
Osborn's checklist	The question list later organised into SCAMPER
Creative Problem Solving (CPS)	Osborn–Parnes structured innovation process
Divergence before convergence	Separate generating from evaluating

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Run generation and evaluation as separate, sequenced phases
- Set a quantity quota to push past obvious ideas
- Enforce 'no criticism' during the divergent phase
- Use the checklist questions to trigger new directions
- Build on others' contributions rather than defend your own

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Later research shows group brainstorming can underperform individuals
- Production blocking and social loafing reduce output
- Dominant voices skew unstructured sessions
- Brainwriting often beats spoken brainstorming for quantity
- The four rules are necessary but not sufficient for quality

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- Coined the term 'brainstorming'; a permanent part of business vocabulary
- Seeded SCAMPER, CPS and modern ideation practice
- Founded the Creative Education Foundation (still active)
- Established 'defer judgement' as the first law of ideation
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Units 1, 2 and 7 ideation tools

SELECTED WORKS

APPLIED IMAGINATION

Principles and Procedures of Creative Thinking

OSBORN · 1953

YOUR CREATIVE POWER

How to Use Imagination

OSBORN · 1948

HOW TO THINK UP

McGraw-Hill

OSBORN · 1942

WAKE UP YOUR MIND

101 Ways to Develop Creativeness

OSBORN · 1952

REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Osborn, A.F. (1953) *Applied Imagination*. New York: Scribner.

Parnes, S.J. and Osborn, A.F. (1992) *Source Book for Creative Problem-Solving*. Buffalo, NY: Creative Education Foundation.